

and check for usability.

Your best guide as to which anti-virus to use is the features it provides. One outstanding feature of avast! that we must mention

before we go into a detailed feature list is that the updates are small and frequent, unlike, for example, in Norton. Every couple of days, while you're connected to the Internet, you get a little pop-up that says new virus definitions are available, and it takes just a few seconds for the update process.

When you first install avast!, the two icons that appear might confuse you—"why are there two icons?" Actually, the first is the VRDB icon, and the second is the on-access scanner icon. Quickly choose (via a right-click) to merge the two icons, and there you are—one little blue ball.

The blue-ball icon looks cool. When it's 'blocked', with a red cross, the providers aren't running; when it's grey, avast! is waiting for something to happen, and when it's blue, everything's OK. However, the icon's animation can be a little irritating—whenever you open (or close) anything (including the screensaver!), the little blue ball rotates for a while.

All menus can be accessed from that icon via a right-click. You can easily pause and re-start resident scanning. Updates—for the program itself or for virus definitions—are easily accessible from right here, though you won't use this much—courtesy the automatic updates. And there are lots of options you can change to change the way the program works: just do this once, then just let the program sit in the system tray and do its work!



avast! settings are easy to understand. And how you update is up to you—manual or automatic